FCPS ACE Italian 200 - Notes

SG

May 2, 2026

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Preface

This document holds notes for the class I took in Spring 2026, *Italian 200 for Beginners and Travelers*. Each class is a chapter. The notes closely match what we cover in class, with additional comments, explanations for my own use, and examples I've picked up. The notes may (likely do!) contain mistakes.

Chapter 1

Apr 27

Topics *Intro to the past tense. Sentences with the past tense. Grammar analysis.*

1.1 Grammar

1.1.1 Past tense - *passato prossimo*

In English, 'I have spoken' and 'I spoke' are grammatically equivalent in everyday use. In Italian, everyday speech and writing uses the latter form, with *essere* and *avere* acting as helper verbs. The past tense therefore uses a three-word structure: *subject, helper-verb, past-participle.*

Broadly speaking, transitive verbs use *avere* and intransitive verbs and verbs of motion use *essere*. See [Fil19] and [Rag63] for more explanation.

Verbs that require essere

- *essere*
- *stare*
- *entrare*
- *arrivare*
- *venire*
- *andare*
- *uscire*
- *partire*

To form the past participle, remove the ending of the verb (e.g., *-are, -ere, -ire* and then add *-ato, -uto, -ito* to match. If *essere* is the helper verb, then change the ending to match gender and plurality.

- *comprare* → *comprato*
- *lavorare* → *lavorato*
- *vedere* → *visto*
- *arrivare* → *arrivato* or *arrivata, arrivati*

Unsurprisingly, some verbs are irregular and you just have to learn them.

Examples

- I'm happy because my wife made a really great dish of pasta last night. We watched a good move after dinner.

	Helper: **avere** Verb: **comprare**
io	*ho comprato*
tu	*hai comprato*
lui/lei	*ha comprato*
noi	*abbiamo comprato*
voi	*avete comprato*
loro	*hanno comprato*

Table 1.1: Past tense example: *avere + comprare*

	Helper: **essere** Verb: **andate**
io	*sono andato*
tu	*sei andato*
lui	*è andato*
lei	*è andata*
noi	*siamo andati*
voi	*siete andati*
loro	*sono andati*

Table 1.2: Past tense example: *essere + andare*

Io sono felice perché mia moglie ha hatto un piatto di pasta molto buono ieri sera. Noi abbimamo vitso un buon film dopo cena.

- I said that I worked a lot today and am tired. I don't want to go to the restaurant for dinner. I prefer to stay at home.
  Ho detto che ho lavorato molto oggi e sono stanco. Io non voglio andare al ristorante per cena. Preferisco stare a casa.

1.2 Grammar analysis - sentence corrections

- Test: *Io non sono comprando una casa in Italia perché è molto cara.*
  Should be: *Io non sto comprando una casa in Italia perché è molto cara.*
  Correction: use stare with present participle.

- Test: *Io non posso parla adesso perché io sto lavorando.*
  Should be: *Io non posso parlare adesso perché io sto lavorando.*
  Correction: use infinitive parlare with helper verbs.

- Test: *Mio libro è molto difficile.*
  Should be: *Il mio libro è molto difficile.*
  Correction: Need article with possessives except for family.

- Test: *Io mangio questo piatto di pasta perché è molto buono.*
  Should be: *Io mangio questa piatto di pasta perché è molto buono.*
  Correction: Need to use questa to match gender of pasta, not piatto.

Past participle	Helper: **avere** Irregular verbs
said, told	*detto*
made, did	*fatto*
read	*letto*
seen, saw	*visto*
put	*messo*
wrote, written	*scritto*

Table 1.3: Irregular past participles: all with *avere*

Appendix

Class dates

Apr	27			
May	04	11	18	25
Jun	01	08	15	

Table 4: Class dates

Resources

Things I have found during class. (References should be clickable.)

Books

- [Rag63]: Very old-fashioned, but the book is slim and quick to read.

Online

- [Fil19]: Explanation of past tense *passato prossimo*.

Bibliography

[Fil19] Michael San Filippo. The Italian Passato Prossimo. 2019. URL: https://www.thoughtco.com/italian-present-perfect-tense-2011710.

[Rag63] Olga Ragusa. Essential Italian Grammar. Dover Publications, 1963.